uniformly built and fronted with a stone bench for shoppers, the street itself domed over and lined with water fountains: the first indoor shopping mall. Along it, González de Clavijo saw leather and linen from the Rus', silks and embroidery from China, rubies and diamonds and pearls from India; nutmegs, cloves, and ginger; game, fowl, bread, and fruit; hemp and flax, silver and copper, glass and porcelain, rhubarb and musk. The merchants visiting the city were so numerous that they camped outside the walls, in a tent city of fifty thousand. The royal palace of Samarkand stood inside the city walls, doubly protected by a river that curved through the city and around its walls. Its splendid public garden was so huge that one ambassador's horse, escaping into the leafy retreat, stayed missing for six whole weeks before it could be located.[1]

The Bahmani diplomats, loaded with gifts, begged the Mongol warrior for a favor: could Firoz please become his vassal? Timur was pleased. He graciously accepted, and in exchange sent the message that Firoz could, by his grace, rule over Malwa and Gujarat.

He had not conquered those two small kingdoms, both of which had declared independence after the wreckage of Delhi. Neither had Firoz; in fact, his rival, the sultan of Vijayanagara, was even at that moment busy establishing diplomatic relationships with both. But Firoz accepted anyway. The ceremonial dance between the two was almost meaningless, but not quite; the submission meant that Timur was in no hurry to plow back down and wreck the Bahmani. He remained out of India. For the next decades, the Indian kingdoms would carry on their unending local wars for territory, leaving the Delhi sultans to carry on a ghost existence in the city that had once been the center of empire.[2]

TIMUR TURNED BACK towards the west, where two Turkish empires waited to meet him: the mamluks of Egypt and the Ottoman Turks.

After the collapse of the Il-khanate, the Egyptian sultan had been left as the foremost power in the lands east of the Mediterranean. The Bahri sultanate, drawn from the old regiment that had once protected the Ayyubid ruler of Egypt, had decayed; in 1390 a new mamluk dynasty had claimed the rule of Egypt. The Burji dynasty drew its sultans from a different military regiment, originally made up of slave warriors bought from the Caucasus mountain ranges. Known as the Circassian mamluks, they had long since mingled with the Turks, but kept their own designation. The Circassian mamluk who first ruled after the Bahri, al-Zahir Barquq, took as his palace the great Citadel of Cairo, built by Saladin himself. His dynasty took its nickname from the Arabic word for the citadel's spires, *burj*: they were the